



captains have been blamed for the selection or omission of players would be known to the cricket fans.

Anyway, back to cricket. In the last 10 years or so, the Ranji Trophy has been won by many States that earlier were not even able to qualify for the knockouts. This is a sign of how healthy Indian cricket is and the talent pool coming through now that the game has become a good career option. Many parents, who otherwise would have wanted their children to become doctors, engineers, bureaucrats, or pursue some such professions where income was guaranteed, are now encouraging their children to take up cricket if they see a spark in their child. They know that even if the child is good enough to play Ranji Trophy cricket, he will earn a decent living.

That said, the Ranji fees per match could do with another increase for the next season since the difference between what an ordinary uncapped but lucky player gets for the IPL and what a truly hard-working Ranji player earns is huge. If only other State teams could follow the example of the Mumbai Cricket Association and give a matching amount of fees to what the BCCI

Captain Marvel: Rohit Sharma, who has led India to back-to-back ICC titles, boasts an impressive win-loss record of 27 wins and three losses at ICC limited-overs tournaments. GETTY IMAGES

gives, then the players would get a really good amount commensurate with the number of days they play.

Every State Association gets a hefty subsidy annually from the BCCI, and most of it stays put in a bank instead of being invested in infrastructure building and the development of the game, which is why it is given. So, the States can afford to match the fees that BCCI gives for its Ranji teams. The good news is that there are more and more administrators coming through who love the game and are aware of the need to promote and encourage their teams.

Hopefully, this will translate into good players not leaving the game for alternate careers and staying on to make State cricket, and thereby Indian cricket, stronger by the day — so it continues to win more trophies like Rohit and his boys have done.

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India's Champions Trophy win took away, to a great extent for me, the sorrow of losing not just one of my idols but also one of the nicest human beings, Padmakar 'Paddy' Shivalkar.